to Gandhara. The empire collapsed but Aramaic continued. This explains why the Mauryan emperor used it for transmitting his message. Incidentally, it is from Aramaic that the Kharoshthi form of writing, widely used in north-west India, evolved: Ashoka later used it for another set of messages there. Everywhere else, in the subcontinental mainland, as we have seen, the Mauryan empire's administrators used Prakrit via the Brahmi script. While many different languages will have been spoken across the area, the Mauryan administration had earlier stuck uniformly to Prakrit, the assumption having been that there were enough bilingually fluent people around to translate Prakrit into the locally common tongues. Now, for the first time, and deviating from the practice followed in the rest of the empire, an Ashokan message was composed in two 'foreign' languages, one from Persia and the other from Europe.

The Kandahar situation is not, however, as singular as it seems. Ashoka's edicts were inscribed in languages used here in governmental memoranda. It was a pragmatic decision. If the administrators of large parts of India conducted official business in Prakrit, in this part of Afghanistan the familiarity was with Greek and Aramaic. By using these the administration was ensuring trouble-free dissemination by factoring in the nature of bilingualism here. Greek and Aramaic apart, other languages and dialects are likely to have been spoken in the region, though what these might have been we don't know because they were not used by the local administration—at least not on surviving rocks or anything that has come down to us from that period. Such antique speech forms are likely to have persisted beyond the conquests and inflows of the West. The persistence does not necessarily mean the existence here of separable population clusters—Greeks and Persians, Magadha migrants and indigenous groups. All it means is that while two of the main languages and scripts were used by the administration, people in general continued to speak in earlier auto-